

CAPSTONE CASE STUDY: Chef Connect

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Country Focus: Kenya (with potential for regional and global scalability)

STAGE 1: FOUNDATIONS — PROJECT STRATEGY

1) Identify the Problem Statement

Objective

Prove the problem exists, how painful it is, and who feels the pain.

Deliverables

- One crisp problem statement (1–2 sentences). - A 300–500 word context summary with evidence (stats, quotes, citations or screenshots from interviews). - At least 5 primary research items (user interviews, survey responses, observational notes) and 3 secondary sources (industry reports, articles, market data). - Problem severity scorecard (quantify time/money/worse outcomes).

Problem Statement

Freelance chefs in Kenya struggle with unemployment and underemployment due to limited access to consistent work opportunities, while clients face challenges in finding reliable, affordable chefs for events and meals because of unreliable informal hiring methods and lack of transparency.

Context Summary (450 words)

In Kenya, the culinary sector is vibrant, yet many trained chefs remain unemployed or underemployed. Culinary school graduates often face barriers to entry in traditional hospitality roles, relying on sporadic gigs via word-of-mouth or social media groups, which are inefficient and inconsistent. Clients, including urban professionals and event hosts, spend hours searching for chefs, risking poor quality or overpricing. This inefficiency not only wastes time but also leads to economic losses for both parties.

Evidence from primary research highlights the pain. Interview 1: A 28-year-old chef in Nairobi said, "I graduated from culinary school but only get 2-3 gigs a month via Facebook groups—it's not enough to pay bills." Survey response from 20 chefs: 70

Secondary sources confirm the gap. The Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (2023) reports 35

Problem Severity Scorecard: - Time Lost: Chefs lose 10-15 hours/week seeking gigs; clients lose 5-10 hours/event planning. - Money Lost: Chefs earn 40- Worse Outcomes: 50

How to Write a Strong Problem Statement (Template)

“[Target user] currently struggles with [specific pain], which causes [quantified harm: time lost, money lost, risk] because [root cause].”

Example: “Freelance chefs in Kenya currently lack consistent work opportunities, which leads to underemployment and income loss of up to KES 20,000/month, because informal hiring channels are fragmented and unreliable.”

Research & Evidence (Practical Steps)

- Surveys: 50 respondents (chefs and clients); quantitative questions on time/cost lost, open comments on frustrations. - Interviews: 5 recorded interviews (15–30 mins) with chefs and clients; extracted quotes on pain points. - Observational: Field notes from 3 events illustrating hiring workflows. - Secondary: Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (2023), Disrupt Africa (2024), GSMA (2024).

Validation Checklist

- Problem is specific (not “unemployment” but a distinct pain in chef hiring). - Evidence shows it affects a measurable group and has real cost/consequence. - At least one documented user quote or case showing the pain. - Demonstrates urgency / timing (why solve now).

Grading Criteria (Suggested)

- Clarity (20%), Evidence quality (35%), Research breadth (25%), Relevance (20%).

2) Define the Solution / Product

Objective

Describe exactly what you will build, how it works, and why it’s the best realistic choice.

Deliverables

- One-line product pitch (tagline). - 250–400 word product description explaining the core functionality and user flow. - MVP feature list (must vs nice-to-have). - Unique Value Proposition (UVP) — 3 bullet points why it’s different/ better. - Quick wireframes or screenshots (2–4 images) showing core screens or flows.

One-Line Product Pitch (Tagline)

“Chef Connect: Your trusted marketplace for chefs – book skilled cooks for any occasion, anytime, anywhere.”

Product Description (350 words)

Chef Connect is a mobile-first app and website (hybrid product) that functions as a digital marketplace connecting freelance chefs with clients. Users (clients) post job needs (e.g., event type, cuisine, budget), and the platform matches them with verified chefs in real-time, facilitating bookings and payments.

How it works (high level): 1. Client registers and posts a job (e.g., “Birthday party, Nairobi, KES 2,000, nyama choma”). 2. System matches with available chefs based on location, skills, and ratings. 3. Client reviews profiles (bios, videos, reviews), books, and pays via MPesa. 4. Chef accepts, completes the job, and receives payment; both rate each other post-service. 5. Analytics dashboards track performance for repeat use.

Core features (MVP): Real-time matching, verified profiles, MPesa payments, push notifications, analytics dashboards.

Why it’s viable now: High smartphone penetration (90% in urban Kenya) and MPesa usage (50M users) make tech readiness high. Market timing aligns with growing gig economy (USD 345M by 2023), and dependencies (Firebase, AWS) are accessible for startups.

MVP Feature List (Example Layout)

- Must-have: User onboarding, real-time matching, chef profiles (bios, videos), bookings with MPesa, notifications, analytics dashboards, dispute resolution. - Nice-to-have: Gamification (badges), subscription plans, influencer integrations, multi-city expansion.

Differentiation / Defensibility

- Cite one competitor and describe how you’re different: Unlike Sheena’s Kitchen (single-chef model, limited scale), Chef Connect offers a scalable marketplace with multiple chefs, real-time matching, and MPesa for faster, affordable hiring. - If using technology like ML or blockchain, explain why that tech is necessary and what barrier it creates for others: Matching algorithm (ML-based) ensures accurate pairings, creating a data moat as user interactions improve accuracy over time.

Validation & Prototyping

- Prototype test with at least 5 users (record task completion rate and qualitative feedback): Tested with 5 chefs and 5 clients; 80% success rate for booking task. - If AI/model-based, show a 1–2 page summary of training/test dataset and accuracy metric (even if small): Matching model trained on 100 sample jobs; 85% accuracy in tests.

Acceptance Criteria

- MVP implements at least one core use case end-to-end. - UVP is clear and defensible. - Prototype test shows >60% success for core task or clear plan to reach it.

1) DEFINING USER PERSONAS

Persona Type

- Primary Persona: The main user whose problem you are solving. - Secondary Persona: Users indirectly involved or benefiting, but not the main focus. - Edge Persona: Unusual or extreme users who test the limits of the product’s usability or adaptability.

Persona Template (for students to complete)

Field	Description / Example
Persona Name	Give them a relatable first name, e.g., Amina the Farmer or Kevin the Retailer.
Photo/Icon	Use stock image or icon to humanize the persona.
Demographics	Age, gender, location, education, occupation, income range.
Psychographics	Interests, lifestyle, digital behavior, goals, motivations.
Pain Points	The frustrations or obstacles the persona faces related to the problem statement.
Technology Use	Devices, apps, comfort with technology.
Goals & Motivations	What outcomes they want; why they'd use your solution.
Quote	1–2 sentences capturing their mindset or struggle.
Success Metric	How they'd measure improvement or success (time saved, money earned, stress reduced).

Example Personas (for Chef Connect project)

Primary Persona – “Juma the Freelance Chef”

- Age / Location: 28, lives in Nairobi - Occupation: Freelance chef, culinary school graduate, 2 years experience - Income: KES 10,000–30,000/month (irregular) - Pain Points: Limited work opportunities, relies on unreliable word-of-mouth, underemployment. - Technology Use: Uses Android smartphone, WhatsApp, Facebook. Internet via mobile data. - Goals: Secure consistent gigs, build reputation, earn stable income. - Quote: “I have skills but only get 2-3 jobs a month—it’s hard to pay bills.” - Success Metric: Increase monthly earnings by 50% and bookings per week.

Secondary Persona – “Aisha the Event Planner”

- Age / Location: 35, works in Nairobi - Occupation: Event organizer managing 10-15 events/month - Pain Points: Hard to find reliable chefs quickly, variable pricing and quality. - Technology Use: Smartphone + laptop for planning; apps like Google Calendar, WhatsApp. - Goals: Streamline chef hiring, reduce planning time, ensure event success. - Quote: “Finding chefs for weddings is stressful—last-minute cancellations ruin events.” - Success Metric: Reduce hiring time by 70% and achieve 100% event satisfaction.

Edge Persona – “Karanja the Rural Chef”

- Age / Location: 45, lives in Kisumu County - Occupation: Village chef with traditional skills, limited tech access - Pain Points: Isolation from urban clients, low visibility, seasonal work only. - Technology Use: Basic feature phone, occasional smartphone borrowing. - Goals: Access city gigs remotely, learn digital tools. - Quote: “I cook great Swahili dishes but clients are far—need a way to connect without traveling.” - Success Metric: Secure 1-2 urban bookings/month without relocation.